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To he who desires to conquer

O God, as long as the Sun and Moon shall be,
May Stanford, centre of learning, remain.

To my beloved Stanford,

I have not seen you. I know you only by your name, by photographs, by histories. Yet there are places that enter the heart before the feet ever reach them. Distance does not always diminish a thing; sometimes it purifies it. What the eye has not yet possessed, the imagination is free to approach with reverence.

And so, before I have seen you, I have already begun speaking to you.

The Sufis know that the unseen beloved possesses a peculiar power. What remains distant cannot yet be reduced to habit.

I think of you as a place built, in part, out of loss: a place where grief for one young life was transformed by a family into an inheritance for lives not yet born. There is something mystical in that transformation. Is not this one of the deepest things a human being can do with grief: not conquer it, not explain it, but allow it to become generosity? This thought has stayed with me.

A university, at its highest, should be such a transformation. One enters carrying the small kingdom of the self, one's ambitions, certainties, vanities, fears, and carefully guarded definitions of success, and encounters a world too large to fit inside them! Knowledge then becomes valuable not merely because it adds something to us, but because it removes something. It teaches a person that intelligence without humility is only another kind of blindness. A true education should disturb the borders of the self. What but flesh, mere flesh, separates me from the world outer?

Perhaps this is why the old Sufi image of the cup returns so often to me when I think of learning. The scholar who approaches knowledge only to enlarge his own name may leave with more information and less wisdom. A cup that insists on remaining full cannot receive anything. I am but a beggar of knowledge.

Dear Stanford, from afar, I imagine you. I have not yet earned the right to describe you from memory. That is precisely why these pages are written differently. They are not records of a place I know. They are letters sent toward a place I have not reached.

There is tenderness in writing to the unseen. One must admit from the beginning that imagination may be wrong. Perhaps the places I have invested with symbolism will reveal themselves to be simply buildings where people hurry between appointments, complain about deadlines, drink coffee, lose sleep, laugh, fail, fall in love, and continue with their lives.

I hope so. For if I ever reach you, I do not want reality merely to confirm the idol distance has made. The beloved who exists only to fulfill our imagination is not a beloved at all, but a mirror.

Perhaps this, too, is a Sufi lesson. We begin by loving an image because the image gives longing somewhere to rest. Then, if we are fortunate, the image is taken from us so that we may approach what is real. One veil falls only to reveal another. So I write these verses before arriving.

And perhaps years from now I will read them beneath the very trees I have never seen and smile at the distance between the place I imagined and the place I found. Perhaps I will be embarrassed by my tenderness. Perhaps I will discover that the ordinary you is more beautiful precisely because it is ordinary.

Or perhaps I shall never reach you.

Even then, I would not consider these words wasted. A garden need not be entered to awaken the desire for fragrance. A lamp may be distant and still remind a traveler that darkness is not the whole world.

For now, you remain to me what every true beloved first is: partly known, largely unseen, and powerful because of what it awakens rather than what it possesses.

They say palms stand upon the road leading inward.

Perhaps they are seekers who became trees from standing too long in prayer.

I ask, "Where is Stanford?" and they point toward the West.

The heart laughs: "What place worth seeking was ever found by direction?"

Its gates are unknown to my eyes,
Yet longing has entered where the body has not been admitted yet.

I have heard its walls are made of sandstone;
Dust joined to dust, pretending for a little while to be permanence.

They say one tower there looks over the whole plain.

Whoever climbs high enough discovers that greatness makes men small.

Do not praise the tower because it rises above the earth;
The greater miracle is the earth, which bears the tower and makes no boast.

They tell me Stanford was born from remembrance.
Then its first lesson was written before its first student arrived.
Nothing loved is truly possessed.

Leland Stanford Jr. departed, but his name gathered generations beneath it.
Some graves are dug downward, others open toward the future.

Absence occupies no place, yet leaves no place untouched.

I have heard of the Green Library whose rooms are heavy with books.
A single unread page weighs more than a kingdom to the one who thirsts.
Books are cups from which dead men continue drinking with us;
Their dust is dry, but the wine, oh, it has not grown old.

If Stanford contains a thousand teachers, I seek the one who teaches unlearning;
For the full cup receives nothing from the rain.

They say there are laboratories where matter is divided until it nearly disappears.
The mystic performs the same experiment upon the self.

They seek the smallest particle hidden inside creation.
I seek the smallest "I," that I may discover where it vanishes.

If Stanford teaches me a thousand truths,
May one of them be the poverty of the word "mine."

The scholar places his name beneath his discovery.
The rain signs no paper, yet the whole garden cites it.

They teach machines there to remember.

I envy the machine only this: it does not mistake its memory for a soul.

They speak of Stanford as a place where one may become someone.
To me it is also a place where one may become less.

For the mountain of the self is climbed downward.

I have heard that the earth once shook beneath Stanford and cast its stones down.
Even knowledge must occasionally be reminded upon what it stands.

They raised the fallen walls again.
There is no disgrace in falling; only in returning unchanged.

A repaired arch contains two histories:
The pride of having stood, and the wisdom of having fallen.

The scholar measures the heavens and names what he finds.

The lover sees one star and loses the need for names.

If ever I sit beneath one of Stanford's trees,

May I remember that shade is the tree's charity to a *musafir*.

How many footsteps must have crossed those courts before mine ever may?

Dust keeps every secret and claims none of the travelers.

Do not mock the one who loves what he has never seen.

The moth knows the flame by a law older than sight.

They say Stanford opens many doors.

The most difficult door has no hinge, for it opens inward.

O God, should my eyes ever behold that distant place,

Let them find not what imagination promised, but what the soul required.

They say old arches surround its court.

Perhaps the secret of enduring is not strength, but knowing where to bend?

For the seeker who reaches the shrine still carries himself to its door;

The final pilgrimage begins when even the pilgrim is left behind.

O God, preserve there not knowledge alone,
but the wound from which knowledge springs
For when wonder is healed,
the learned man becomes poorer than the fool.

Perhaps one day my feet will reach the place my imagination has visited for years.
Then I shall learn whether the unseen Stanford was larger than the visible one.